

Coaching & Culture

This section provides a comprehensive suite of development and training frameworks for business advisors, focusing on transitioning from traditional methods to a flipped learning model.

This material is for Firm/Practice owners only and is of a medium complexity level.

1: Flipping The Training Process (Flipping the Learning)

- **Benefits:** This template shifts the firm away from traditional, generic learning paths by utilizing a technology-enabled closed feedback loop. It ensures training is strictly driven by real client needs.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It ensures that the advisory firm's time and resources are explicitly dedicated to learning how to solve the exact, common problems the business owner is currently facing.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It connects their education directly to immediate client outcomes. It removes ambiguity by clarifying exactly "who (in our team) needs to learn what & by when" to deliver the necessary success actions.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** Practice partners, training managers, and HR leaders responsible for mapping out the internal training curriculum and tracking progress.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. **Identify the Problem:** Start by asking, "What are the common problems we see our clients dealing with?"
2. **Work Backwards:** Determine the "Common Success Actions"—the specific actions that will help 'move the needle' for the client in that situation.
3. **Align Internal Operations:** Align internal divisions and develop or edit templates to support client education and problem-solving logic.
4. **Assign Tasks:** Ask "Who needs to learn what, and over what timeframe?" and import these tasks into a timeline/reminder platform.
5. **Monitor & Refine:** Monitor completed tasks and filter reports to find 'Common Failures,' utilizing this data to continuously improve the feedback loop.

1a. Advisor Case Study Prep

- **Benefits:** This template provides a highly structured checklist and workflow for preparing and running internal client review sessions.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It ensures that their business issues are systematically analyzed against a structured framework (Planning & Data, Sales & Marketing, People & Process) and that any new ideas are tested in a revenue model before real-world business changes are made.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It gives the advisor a definitive roadmap for preparation. It outlines exactly what they need to do prior to a meeting (the Golden Hr prep), and provides a structured way to capture ideas and objections from peers (in the Platinum Hr) before facing the client.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** Advisors who are actively preparing for a client review, or those ready to present a client case study to their internal team for feedback.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. **Load & Select:** Create the business entity in Advisor-e and select the most industry-appropriate revenue model.
 2. **Structure the Plan:** Open the Client Service Plan and add regular content like dashboard reports, revenue models, and agenda notes.
 3. **Analyze Issues:** Think of the client's issues against the "Get Organised, Get the Job, Do the Job" framework to see which domain needs the most help.
 4. **Review Content:** Select a supporting template, watch the tutorial video, note any desired changes, and log the time in your CPD log.
 5. **Run the Session:** Start by introducing the client financials and observed trends, explain your service offer, open the floor to peers for ideas, and capture those ideas in the client service plan while in session.
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1b: Team Training O.S

- **Benefits:** This template provides clear "Field Outcome Statements" that define the responsibilities, boundaries, and expected coaching requirements across different advisory tiers.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Ensures the client is matched with an advisor functioning at the correct level of expertise—whether that is software training or facilitating complex, conflict-based business solutions.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It sets crystal clear career expectations. An 'Associate Advisor' knows they are expected to manage accounts proactively but aren't required to hunt for

new prospects. A 'Strategic Advisor' knows exactly what skills they need to master to become a future 'Partnership Option'.

- **Who it may be suitable for:** Management tracking the "Professional's Journey," and team members looking to understand their specific role boundaries and upward progression paths.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. **Assess Capability:** Identify the team member's baseline skills (e.g., intimate knowledge of software and tools).
2. **Assign Role & Boundaries:** Map them to the corresponding tier (e.g., Advisory Support) and enforce boundaries (e.g., they will not be required to conduct meetings in isolation).
3. **Target Coaching:** Provide coaching specific to that role via the Advisor-e Support framework (e.g., software orientation for Support roles; advanced facilitation and consultative sales for Strategic roles).
4. **Advance Responsibilities:** As skills increase, transition responsibilities (e.g., moving a Support member to Support + where they run educational client meetings as a testing ground for the Associate role).

1c: Building Learning Culture

- **Benefits:** This template establishes the framework for a transparent environment of constant improvement, providing the "rules of engagement" for a safe, non-judgmental team culture.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It guarantees that the advice they receive is not isolated; it is the product of an entire advisory team that constantly validates their field intelligence through structured group feedback.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It creates a "Social Contract" that makes them feel safe. It removes the fear of critique by stating that "nobody's perfect" and provides structured scripts so they can share vulnerabilities and receive peer feedback without taking offense.
- **Who it may be suitable for:** The entire organization, as a visible learning culture requires that "EVERYBODY participates... no exceptions".

Step-by-Step Method:

1. **Independent Prep:** A team member begins in their "Golden Hr," working on their own to force active participation in their personal learning and development.
2. **Group Transition:** The member transitions to the "Platinum Hr" session, which is dedicated specifically to team feedback and group problem solving.

3. **Present the Case:** The member uses the structured "Platinum Case Study Format" to present the client's financials, observed trends, and service offer to the team.
4. **Validate via Feedback:** The rest of the team uses the VISIBLE Learning Culture Feedback Model to explicitly state what "stands out," what they want to clarify/challenge, and to validate the presenter.
5. **Review Real-World Output:** After dealing with the client, the member returns to the next Platinum Hr to run a 'Review' session detailing what went well, what went less well, and future actions.

Common Q&A

Q1: What is the primary difference between a Golden Hr and a Platinum Hr? A: The Golden Hr is designated for a team member to do on their own, forcing them to take an active part in their personal learning. The Platinum Hr is designed specifically for team member feedback and group "problem solving".

Q2: What is the core characteristic of a learning culture? A: A learning culture is an environment of constant improvement that is completely transparent and free from judgment. It relies on the inclusion of everybody without exception.

Q3: How does the "Flipping the Training Process" differ from a Traditional Learning Path? A: A traditional path starts by determining what the firm wants to deliver. The flipped process starts by asking what common problems clients are facing, and then works backwards to figure out what internal training is required to solve those specific issues.

Q4: Will an "Advisory Support +" team member need to find and secure new clients? A: No. While they may run specific educational client meetings, they are guided by a partner regarding who they deal with and are not required to scope or secure engagements.

Q5: What are the expectations of a "Strategic Advisor"? A: They must be able to approach new prospects, build networks, conduct total needs client discovery, scope and price engagements, manage 'A' client accounts, and act as future "Partnership Options".

Q6: Why is structured feedback so important in this framework? A: It ensures that field intelligence and group learning are validated, not left to chance. It builds contextual awareness while maintaining a feeling of safety and inclusion.

2. Coaching Progress Plan

Benefits: A comprehensive spreadsheet tracking a 60-session coaching curriculum, including pricing models, hours, and specific skills training. How it helps the Business Owner: Provides measurable ROI on coaching by clearly mapping topics, planned attendees, and delivery hours against specific field outcomes. How it helps the Advisor: Gives a predictable, structured pathway to build their skillset, transitioning from technical software usage to advanced soft skills (e.g., sales framing, COI development). Suitable for: Practice managers and advisors managing long-term professional development.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Review the pricing model and total coaching hours allocated for the period.
2. Identify the next chronological session (e.g., Framing 1A) and note the specific skill outcome.
3. Complete the minimum required preparation (e.g., watching assigned tutorial videos).
4. Conduct the coaching session with the designated team members.
5. Measure success against the stated field objective before moving to the next module.

3. FM Hiring Winners

Benefits: A strategic slide deck covering recruitment theory, leadership alignment, candidate screening, and orientation frameworks. How it helps the Business Owner: Prevents the extreme financial cost of a bad hire by defining the firm's leadership style, flushing out appropriate talent, and testing applicants rigorously. How it helps the Advisor/New Hire: Provides a structured "Buddy System" during orientation that validates their career choice and offers safe, immediate tasks. Suitable for: Leadership teams and HR managers actively preparing to recruit and onboard new staff.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Define your personal leadership style (e.g., Creative Abrasion vs. Creative Resolution).
2. Assess role requirements against the organizational structure to see if a full-time hire is genuinely needed.
3. Flush out talent by placing creative job ads in non-traditional locations.
4. Grade applicants through a 3-stage process: Feel (Meeting 1), Know (Meeting 2), and Test (Meeting 3).
5. Implement the structured AM/PM orientation table for the new hire's first two days.

3a. FM Leadership.1

Benefits: A questionnaire evaluating the fundamental alignment between a leader's personality and the business's cultural needs. How it helps the Business Owner: Ensures the leadership style being deployed is actually suited to the firm's specific industry (e.g., an accounting firm needing strict compliance vs. a creative design agency). How it helps the Advisor (Leader): Helps them identify the pros and cons of 'Creativity' vs. 'Discipline' cultures, preventing them from blindly mimicking leadership styles that don't fit their personality. Suitable for: Senior leadership teams defining the strategic operational culture of the firm.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. List the pros and cons of a 'Creativity' culture versus a 'Discipline' culture for your firm.
2. Identify what behavior your current leadership style attempts to reflect in others.
3. Document any specific individuals you have modeled your leadership style upon.
4. Analyze if your desired culture, industry needs, and personal traits are authentically aligned.

3b. FM Leadership 2

Benefits: A self-reflection questionnaire challenging leaders to evaluate their inclusivity and response to disagreement. How it helps the Business Owner: Ensures leadership blind spots do not create a toxic environment that stifles diversity or silences valuable input from junior staff. How it helps the Advisor (Leader): Forces profound self-awareness, asking them if they value "being right" more than finding the best solution for the team. Suitable for: Existing partners, practice managers, and emerging leaders.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Rate your firm's business culture on a scale of 1 to 10.
2. Reflect on how actively you seek diversity when recruiting.
3. Assess how inclusive your meetings are (e.g., do you call on the "quiet ones at the back"?).
4. Evaluate if you demonstrate healthy respect for all team members regardless of position.
5. Honestly document how you cope when a team member disagrees with your opinion.
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3c. FM Team 'CANOE' Review

Benefits: A 360-degree review spreadsheet measuring five observable personality traits: Conscientiousness, Agreeableness, Neuroticism, Openness, and Extraversion. How it helps the Business Owner: Collates team averages to highlight trait "gaps," ensuring future job advertisements seek complementary skills rather than cloning existing personalities. How it

helps the Advisor: Builds emotional intelligence by comparing "How I see myself" directly against "How others see me." Suitable for: Whole teams undergoing synergy audits or managers preparing a hiring plan.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Allocate up to 5 colleagues to observe each team member privately.
2. Have each individual complete the self-assessment based on provided trait indicators.
3. Have the designated peers complete their observation assessments.
4. Collate the data into the "Team Summary" spreadsheet.
5. Analyze the combined averages to identify areas lacking team diversity.

3d. Job Ad Assoc

Benefits: A pre-written job advertisement template designed to recruit an Associate Advisor. How it helps the Business Owner: Saves drafting time and clearly outlines the firm's specific expectations, including starting fee base targets (\$135,000) and allotted training hours. How it helps the Advisor (Applicant): Clearly defines the "partnership pathway," the exact size of the portfolio they will manage, and the structural support available. Suitable for: Hiring managers actively seeking to recruit ambitious mid-level accountants.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Customize the firm name and regional district details.
2. Adjust the starting fee base and client numbers to match internal capacity.
3. Publish the ad in targeted recruitment areas.
4. Request applicants submit a short video to demonstrate their communication skills.
5. Grade applicants against the stated partnership pathway criteria.
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4. Paper Tower Model

Benefits: A financial spreadsheet calculator designed to measure the profit or loss of a team construction exercise. How it helps the Business Owner: Translates soft skills (team communication, planning) into hard financial metrics, vividly proving how inefficiency hurts the bottom line. How it helps the Advisor (Participant): Demonstrates firsthand how rushing into action without a plan leads to material waste and financial loss. Suitable for: Workshop facilitators running team-building and conflict resolution exercises.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Wait for the team to complete the physical tower build.

2. Input the exact number of minutes taken into the spreadsheet.
3. Input the number of paper batches drawn (\$2,000 cost per batch of 20).
4. Measure and input the final height of the tower in millimeters.
5. Review the auto-calculated final profit or loss figure and announce it to the group.

4a. Paper Tower Review Questions

Benefits: A facilitator's debrief script that breaks down the psychology and dynamics observed during the Paper Tower exercise. How it helps the Business Owner: Translates a simple game into a profound business lesson, introducing the 9-step team process for managing future corporate projects. How it helps the Advisor (Participant): Exposes whether they rely on chaotic "outcome-oriented" behavior or structured "process-driven" logic. Suitable for: Facilitators guiding the post-exercise reflection session.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Ask the group if their objective was accurately defined and if a financial calculation was done prior to building.
2. Read back exact, timestamped observations of what team members said during the exercise.
3. Ask the group if they were outcome-oriented or process-driven.
4. Reveal the 9-step team process (Appoint Chairperson, Determine SMART Objective, Brainstorm without assessment, etc.).
5. Facilitate a discussion on how this 9-step process can be applied to real work tasks.

4b. Paper Tower Task Sheet

Benefits: The strict, formal rule sheet provided to participants outlining the constraints of the tower exercise. How it helps the Business Owner (Facilitator): Sets indisputable boundaries that create artificial pressure to test team dynamics safely. How it helps the Advisor (Participant): Forces the team to manage strict deadlines (30 minutes total) against the high cost of materials. Suitable for: Teams directly participating in the Paper Tower workshop.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Read the objective: Build a tower profitably based on materials, height, and time.
2. Receive the initial 100 sheets of paper.
3. Utilize the strict 20-minute planning phase (no prefabrication allowed).
4. Execute the build within the strict 10-minute construction phase.
5. Ensure the completed tower stands self-supported for at least one minute.

4c. Spaghetti Tower Task Sheet

Benefits: An alternative team construction exercise focusing strictly on structural stability and height rather than financial profitability. How it helps the Business Owner (Facilitator): Tests the team's ability to prototype and communicate under pressure using highly fragile materials. How it helps the Advisor (Participant): Challenges their physical execution, creativity, and collaborative problem-solving skills. Suitable for: Teams needing an engaging icebreaker or physical communication test.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Review the rules: Build the tallest tower possible within 30 minutes.
2. Collect the exact resources: 20 sticks of spaghetti, tape, 1 meter of string, and 2 marshmallows.
3. Utilize the 20-minute preparation phase without prefabricating materials.
4. Construct the tower in the final 10 minutes, placing 1 complete marshmallow at the very top.
5. Ensure the structure stands self-supported for one minute before measuring.

4d. Team Workshop Run Sheet

Benefits: A minute-by-minute logistical schedule dictating the flow of a comprehensive two-day team workshop. How it helps the Business Owner: Maximizes the ROI of taking staff offline by ensuring the event runs flawlessly on time without momentum loss. How it helps the Advisor (Facilitator): Removes the stress of event management by providing exact timings for content blocks, breaks, and daily reviews. Suitable for: Event facilitators and managers organizing internal firm retreats or training days.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Review the overarching schedule for Day 1 and Day 2.
2. Prepare content specifically to fit the designated 90-minute session blocks.
3. Adhere strictly to the designated start and finish times for morning tea and lunch breaks.
4. Execute the required 10-minute management reviews within the schedule.
5. Conclude each day strictly with the allocated 30-minute "Day Review" session.

5. Advisory PIP Template

Benefits: Formalizes a Performance Improvement Plan (PIP) specifically tailored for advisory roles and software adoption. How it helps the Business Owner: Protects the firm against potential fee loss and toxic culture by strictly documenting underperformance and preventing vocal resistance from undermining the visible learning culture. How it helps the Advisor: Removes all ambiguity by stating exactly what their performance gap is, outlining specific behaviors to *start* and *stop* doing, and detailing the exact mentorship available. Suitable for: Team members failing to meet minimum pre/post-meeting portal expectations or resisting advisory engagement.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. Document the exact data metric of failure (e.g., 30 assigned clients but only 14 portal entities created).
 2. Clarify the firm's minimum expectations for loading financials and tagging post-meeting actions.
 3. Define specific actions the employee must implement and behaviors they must cease immediately.
 4. Assign a specific partner or mentor for role-play and software support.
 5. Schedule strict review milestones (e.g., 30, 60, and 90 days).
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Common Q&A

1. What is the difference between a "Golden Hr" and a "Platinum Hr"?

A: The Golden Hr is designed for an individual team member to prepare on their own (e.g., watching tutorials, loading clients into the portal), forcing them to take active ownership of their learning. The Platinum Hr is a collaborative group session designed specifically for team member presentations, receiving structured feedback, and group problem-solving.

2. What is the 9-step team process taught during the Tower exercises?

A: The 9-step process helps teams move from chaotic outcomes to process-driven logic. It requires teams to: 1. Appoint a Chairperson, 2. Appoint a Timekeeper/Scribe, 3. Determine a S.M.A.R.T objective, 4. Apportion time, 5. Brainstorm *without* assessment, 6. Assess options, 7. Eliminate/select the best option, 8. Allocate resources, and 9. Prepare and implement the action plan.

3. How should an interviewer handle an applicant who fails the 'Feel' stage of an interview?

A: If an applicant fails the Meeting 1 'Feel' stage (where you use open-ended questions to gauge traits) badly, you should stop the interview process there. If they don't do great but appear to have the right technical skills, you proceed to the Meeting 2 'Know' stage but bring in an alternative interviewer to help reduce your personal bias.

4. What is the purpose of using a 3rd person persona when approaching a Center of Influence (COI)?

A: When dealing with guarded prospects (like "Mr. Prickly"), using a 3rd person persona and the "Event, Cause, Effect" method allows you to discuss sensitive issues without asking the prospect to expose their own weaknesses. This allows them to "save face," lowers their defensive filters, and positions you as a credible problem solver rather than a salesperson.

5. How does 'Flipping the Learning' differ from traditional training?

A: Traditional training starts by determining what a manager wants to deliver, developing content, and having an advisor present it. "Flipping" the process uses a closed loop that starts by identifying common *client* problems. You then work backward to determine what the client needs to do, what the advisor needs to learn to facilitate that, and finally, track the tasks to find common failures to update the templates.

6. What is 'Creative Abrasion' in leadership?

A: Creative Abrasion is a leadership style found in highly innovative teams where healthy debate is expected and encouraged. Teams amplify their differences and clash ideas against each other to find better solutions. The fundamental rule for this to work is that when they debate, they strictly "play the ball and not the player," ensuring no personal attacks occur.